

SEPHORA

CAREER

GUIDEBOOK



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CAREER DEVELOPMENT SKILLS AND STRATEGIES
GROUP A (SEPHORA/LVMH)

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- **Yelyzaveta Shtanko** (*Trade Marketing Assistant at Thélios France*)
- **Ilaria Brizio** (*Former Sales Associate at Louis Vuitton Monaco*)





1. INTRODUCTION

INTRODUCTION

This guidebook offers a comprehensive introduction to entering the corporate world of Sephora under the LVMH group, with a specific focus on the European job market.

Initially, our research focused on the LVMH parent group due to its global position in the luxury industry. We then narrowed our focus to Sephora because of its unique role within the group. As both a multi-brand retailer and a brand owner through Sephora Collection, Sephora offers a wider range of career opportunities across functions such as merchandising, marketing, operations, and digital strategy. It must also maintain its own brand identity while working with numerous external brands, which adds complexity to its business model.

Sephora's position within LVMH also makes it a potential entry point into both the beauty and luxury industries. While Sephora is not a luxury brand, it operates within the premium segment of the beauty industry and is closely connected to the wider LVMH network, which may provide broader career pathways over time.

While Sephora is widely recognized in the United States for its position in the beauty retail market, much of the available information is centered on the U.S. context and is relatively easy to access. In contrast, the European market is often difficult to access due to language barriers, its predisposition to informal networking structures, and the generally closed nature of the beauty and luxury industries. However, as the headquarters of both Sephora and LVMH are based in France, Europe represents a key center for decision-making, strategy, and brand development. Furthermore, while Sephora U.S. has well-known competitors such as Ulta Beauty and Sally Beauty, Sephora in Europe occupies a unique position as a leading beauty retailer with a strong brand presence and access to more creative career opportunities due to its proximity to headquarters.

Both Europe and the beauty industry can be challenging fields to break into, especially for those just beginning their job search. This guidebook was designed to address this gap by filtering through the foreign-language materials and combining them with practical insights from interviews with professionals working in Sephora, LVMH-affiliated companies, and related areas within the luxury sector. In doing so, it aims to collect the fragmented information and make it more understandable for students and aspiring job seekers.



2. BUSINESS & INDUSTRY OVERVIEW

Business Model
Why Sephora?
Sephora in Europe
Industry Trends



BUSINESS MODEL

Sephora operates as a leading global prestige beauty retailer under LVMH, with over 2,500 stores in 30+ countries and strong omnichannel growth. Its business focuses on **curated multi-brand assortments**, experiential retail, and data-driven loyalty programs amid a booming cosmetics market projected to exceed \$700 billion by the 2030s.

Sephora's hybrid model combines curated multi-brand retail (prestige, indie, and private-label like Sephora Collection), high-margin services, and a Retail Media Network for brand ads. Revenue stems from product sales (open-sell "try before you buy" in-store), omnichannel features (app bookings, virtual try-on, BOPIS), and the tiered **Beauty Insider loyalty program for personalized retention**. LVMH backing enables global scale, exclusive partnerships (e.g., Fenty Beauty), and investments in experiential stores and data analytics.

REVENUE STREAMS

There are three main revenue streams within prestige beauty retail:

- **Product sales**
 - Multi-brand curation, Sephora Collection private label
- **Services and experiences**
 - Beauty Studio consultations, classes
- **Advertising and partnerships**
 - Retail Media Network, brand exclusives

As its name suggests, prestige beauty retail provides a platform that enables consumers to discover, try, and purchase curated cosmetics, skincare, and fragrance. The two categories are the cable-supported method, parallel to traditional department stores, and the over-the-top method, which is direct-to-consumer digital selling.

Unlike more traditional retail supplied by department stores or pharmacies, OTT beauty via apps/social offers high-speed personalization; such companies include Sephora, Ulta, Douglas.

WHY SEPHORA?

Sephora sells beauty as an experience, not just as retail, with stronger global brand power, more curated discovery, and higher store productivity. Sephora focuses on discovery, trendiness, and exclusivity. Compared to other beauty retailers, Sephora has a more premium, youthful, and global brand image.

SEPHORA IN EUROPE

Sephora's key advantage in Europe is its mix of curation, experience, and digital convenience, which makes it more than just a store. It wins customers by offering a more exciting shopping experience than pharmacies or department stores, and more trust and discovery than many online-only sites. The strongest challenge is that Europe already has many established beauty retailers, so Sephora must keep investing in brand exclusives, localized assortments, and loyalty.



SEPHORA IN FRANCE

In France, Sephora's business model is centered on prestige beauty retail, meaning curated brands, in-store testing, beauty advice, and a strong omnichannel experience.

France is also important because Sephora can use its home-market presence to test new concepts, flagship-store experiences, and digital features before expanding them elsewhere.

Sephora's advantage in France is its brand image, premium assortment, and experiential shopping, while competitors often compete more on price, pharmacy access, or convenience.

SEPHORA IN ITALY

In Italy, Sephora competes in a market where beauty retail is shaped by department stores, pharmacy-style retail, and strong local beauty chains.

Sephora's business model in Italy still relies on store experience, beauty discovery, and omnichannel shopping, but it must adapt to local consumer habits and regulations.

Italy is also a market where brand image matters a lot, so Sephora's use of influencers and youth-oriented marketing can create both visibility and risk.

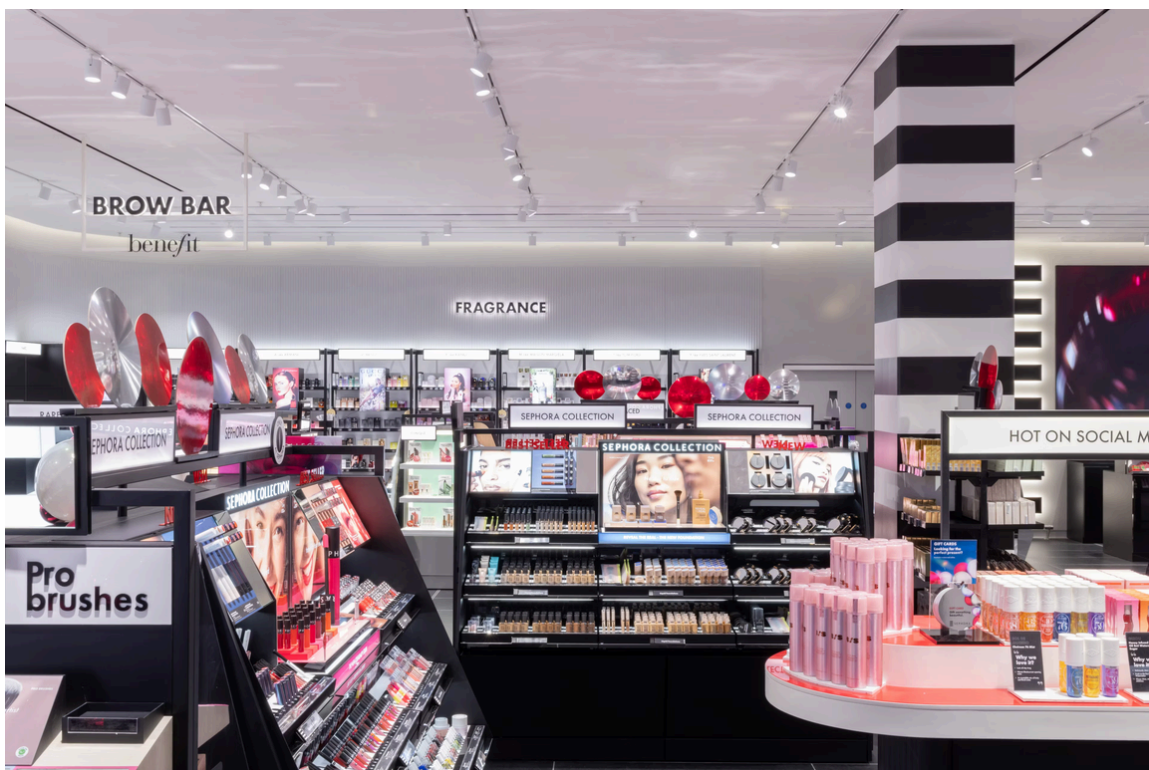
INDUSTRY OVERVIEW

CURRENT TRENDS

There has also been an increase of new players within the market, such as indie clean beauty brands delivering quick trends. These new companies, however, are quickly falling behind because of their lack of 'killer curation.' To this extent, investments in exclusive partnerships reflect another trend.

FUTURE TRENDS

Some believe that although the growth of beauty retail is not over, popularity will soon reach its peak in mature markets. There will be new entries offering different, new experiences from existing competitors, but this will not be as appealing considering their lack of willingness to expand into developing markets, such as Asia. Still, according to industry forecasts, the global prestige beauty market is expected to grow with a CAGR of 7-10% over the forecast period, leaving the possibility for short-term growth. Given the highly competitive atmosphere, future tactics include AI personalization, sustainability, and experiential retail to survive. Consumers have an average of 3+ beauty loyalty programs—showing willingness to pay for more than one service; this means a retailer's brand depth and accessibility will be a great indicator.





3. CAREER PATH

**Corporate Culture & Benefits
Departments & Roles Offered
Career Progression
Interview & Recruitment Process
How Students Can Prepare**

CORPORATE CULTURE

Sephora's corporate culture is dedicated to fostering an environment where individuals and groups feel empowered, valued, and able to express themselves. Diversity and inclusion are among Sephora's core values. The company strives to improve employee retention and the work environment for all employees through an inclusive workplace culture. Specifically, Sephora utilizes best practices to develop inclusive initiatives for hiring individuals with physical or cognitive disabilities.

Sephora's values of teamwork, respect, passion, innovation, initiative, expertise, and balance form the foundation of its corporate culture, brand, and operations. Sephora encourages all employees to contribute to beauty through teamwork, community, and empowerment, inspiring the industry and delighting customers with meaningful work. Sephora's mission as a leader in prestige omni-retail is to create a welcoming beauty shopping experience for everyone and to inspire fearlessness within its community. The company aims to make an impact in beauty and beyond by embracing innovation, exploration, and creativity.



COMPANY BENEFITS

1. Health Benefits

- **Medical Insurance:**

- **France:** All employees are provided with supplemental health insurance (Mutuelle). This covers medical expenses not reimbursed by the state healthcare system, minimizing the financial burden on employees. (Employers cover at least 50% of the premium).
- **UK:** High-quality private medical insurance plans are provided to ensure prompt and professional medical services.

- **Life & Disability Insurance:**

- The Prévoyance system in France protects employees' livelihoods in the event of long-term illness or disability.
- Life insurance benefits are included to prepare for unforeseen accidents, covering a level equivalent to twice the employee's annual salary.

2. Financial Benefits

- **Industry-Leading Paid Time Off (PTO):**
 - **France:** We support complete rejuvenation by providing 5 to 5.5 weeks of generous annual leave, exceeding legal requirements.
 - **UK:** In addition to basic leave, we offer flexible options to purchase up to 5 additional days of paid time off per year.
- **Flexible Working Systems:** Flexible working hours are applied according to the nature of the job. Notably, we lead efficient work cultures through the recently introduced 4-day work week in regions like France.
- **Mental Health Care:** Beyond physical health, we consistently operate professional counseling and mental health support programs to help maintain emotional stability.

3. Employee Discounts

- **Strong Discount Benefits:**
 - A 30% discount is provided on all products.
 - A 40% discount is applied when purchasing our private label, Sephora Collection.
 - These benefits are stackable, meaning they can be applied even to products already on promotion or sale.
- **Product Samples:** To ensure our employees experience the latest beauty trends first, we regularly provide free product samples and testing opportunities.

4. Professional Development and Wellbeing Support

- **Sephora University:** Through our in-house specialized educational institution, we provide systematic training in retail, service, and professional technical skills.
- **Professional Upskilling:** We support the acquisition of professional certifications such as Makeup Artist and Skincare Specialist, and operate language education programs for global collaboration.
- **Mentorship & Coaching:** We provide 1:1 mentorship with experienced seniors to help set career roadmaps and pass on practical business insights.

DEPARTMENTS & ROLES

Sephora offers various roles across its retail stores, corporate offices, and distribution centers throughout Europe. Recruitment is active in several European countries, including France, Italy, Germany, the UK, and Spain.

1. Retail Operations

The Retail Operations department encompasses diverse tasks such as ensuring customer satisfaction, managing inventory, achieving sales targets, visual merchandising, and team management.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Actively manage customer satisfaction and feedback, along with employee productivity and engagement.
- Ensure inventory availability, merchandise replenishment efficiency, and compliance with operational routines.
- Manage performance against sales targets, category development, and key retail metrics (e.g., MS, IPT, AVB, CR).
- Comprehensively manage one or more of the four main product categories in-store, which include makeup, skincare, fragrance, and the Sephora Collection.
- Ensure product presentation according to visual merchandising specifications, maintain assortment and merchandise, and ensure that the sales floor is well-stocked.
- Store merchandise in the warehouse and on the sales floor, conduct inventory, and operate cash registers.
- Facilitate communication between managers and beauty advisor teams, support managers in daily activities, and contribute to the development of commercial and HR strategies.
- Monitor and analyze team KPIs, motivate teams to achieve goals, train new employees, and guide their growth.
- Implement company procedures (regulations, safety procedures) and commercial policies (pricing, promotions).
- Assist customers with product recommendations, demonstrations, sales support, inventory management, and store operations.
- Support store managers, develop and coach teams, help achieve sales targets, manage inventory, and ensure customer service.
- Participate in a 6-month program for the store manager role, gaining comprehensive practical experience in all key areas of store management.

- Manage, develop, and coach assistant managers and staff, and conduct career and employee evaluations.
- Take full responsibility for achieving monthly and annual sales targets.
- Manage and lead teams in a retail environment to achieve their objectives.
- Provide expert advice and demonstrations on skincare products and routines to customers, promoting sales.
- Offer expert advice on makeup products and application techniques to customers.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Comparable experience or interest in the beauty, cosmetics, retail, fashion, or hospitality sectors.
- Experience in retail and customer advisory roles.
- Excellent communication skills with customers.
- Good knowledge of the beauty industry and trends.
- A dynamic attitude with flexibility and resilience.
- Strong product knowledge, excellent customer service skills, and a passion for the beauty industry.
- Team player who thrives in a collaborative, goal-oriented environment.
- Quick learning ability.
- A valid license to perform services such as waxing, makeup, and false lash application.
- Customer-oriented and business-driven mindset (for store manager trainees).
- Leadership and team management experience, with an empathetic management style.
- Knowledge of key commercial KPIs and confidence in budget management, analysis, and daily reporting.
- Basic knowledge of SAP and Excel.
- Proficiency in English and local languages.

- **Positions Available**

- Beauty Consultant/Beauty Advisor: Full-time or part-time
- Stock Assistant / Cashier: Full-time
- Store Manager Trainee: 6-month program
- Makeup Artist



2. Marketing

The Marketing department is responsible for developing and executing marketing plans, managing campaigns, and fostering brand partnerships to drive sales and expand the customer base.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Establish marketing plans for Sephora-led key activation moments, aiming to boost brand sales and grow the customer base.
- Collaborate with brand marketing and internal stakeholders to optimize programs by leveraging Sephora's marketing capabilities.
- Deeply understand brand priorities and products to coordinate global marketing, marketing experts, and market input, and to develop appropriate actions with brand marketing teams.
- Lead major marketing projects related to category strategy, for example, A+ launches, disruptive Sephora-led events, engaging relevant stakeholders.
- Conduct data-driven activation reports and marketing reviews to track marketing campaign performance, performing first-level performance analysis through agreed KPIs across functions and countries.
- Work with media and creative agencies and internal stakeholders, including Paris headquarters, to ensure smooth communication.
- Contribute to the planning and coordination of paid social and full-funnel co-advertising media campaigns (display, DOOH, video, performance).
- Manage campaign documentation, organizing assets and data structurally and efficiently, ensuring campaigns are delivered on time and as planned.
- Support the build and execution of email and app campaigns, including briefing, testing, and scheduling.
- Develop and execute integrated marketing strategies to enhance brand awareness and increase market share.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Proactive problem-solving and analytical skills, with the ability to anticipate obstacles and quickly generate alternative solutions or ideas, are important.
- Must possess effective written and verbal communication skills.
- Excellent organizational and time management skills are necessary.
- Strong leadership, relationship-building skills, and a proven ability to work effectively in highly cross-functional teams are required.
- A passion for Sephora, its programs, customers, store employees, and marketing is essential.
- Must be able to lead cross-functional collaboration with marketing, visual merchandising, sales, CRM, and digital teams.
- Proficiency in English and local languages.

- The ability to work systematically and organized in a fast-paced, dynamic environment is necessary, along with proficiency in social media and digital platforms.
- A strong interest in digital marketing trends and a passion for the beauty industry are prerequisites.
- Strong communication skills to comfortably work in English within an international environment are needed.
- Enjoy working in teams on collaborative, cross-market projects.

- **Positions Available:**

- Digital & Social Media Intern
- Intern Trade Marketing
- CRM Internship
- Assistant Category Manager
- Junior National Account Manager
- Graduate Leadership Program – Media Marketing
- Brand & Communications Intern

3. Sales

The Sales department focuses on building strong partnerships between brands and retailers and achieving sales targets through key account management.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Build strong brand and retailer partnerships through Sephora EU accounts.
- Successfully execute brand strategic initiatives within the Sephora EU ecosystem.
- Manage performance metrics, collaborate with various teams, and lead key discussions to ensure seamless execution.
- Achieve sales targets, promote brand image, and provide personalized luxury service to customers.
- Effectively manage inventory levels of wholesale accounts to meet sales objectives and optimize inventory quality.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Fluency in English and French is preferred.
- Travel may be necessary.
- Experience in retail, customer service, or store operations (cash and inventory) is essential.
- A strong passion for makeup, skincare, and fragrance, along with product knowledge and application skills, is required.

- **Positions Available:**

- Sales Associate & Stock Assistant
- Retail & Merchandising Internship
- Graduate Program & Trainee

4. Human Resources

The Human Resources department supports HRD and HR teams in compensation and benefits, HR administration, control, reporting, and analysis, playing a critical role in shaping the employee experience.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Support HRD and HR teams in aspects of C&B, HR administration, control, reporting, and analysis.
- Assist and oversee the design and implementation of compensation and benefits programs, including monitoring retail salary structures and annual salary reviews.
- Monitor HR-related KPIs (including headcount and costs) and support follow-up on headquarters and retail salary budget KPIs.
- Conduct cost analysis to assess the financial impact of proposed changes and ensure cost-effectiveness.
- Review and improve HR processes to enhance reliability and data integrity, and to uphold ethical standards.
- Manage the entire recruitment process for designated areas, including needs assessment, profiling, selection, interviews, and onboarding.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Extensive experience in compensation and benefits and/or HR operations within large matrix organizations, particularly in the retail, hospitality, or service industries, is required.
- Deep expertise in compensation practices, market trends, and regulatory requirements is necessary.
- Excellent communication and presentation skills to simplify and convey complex information are crucial.
- Hands-on experience with HRIS, analytical thinking, and a KPI-driven mindset are essential.
- Fluency in German and English is required, and French and/or Scandinavian language skills are a plus.
- CIPD qualification (or working towards one) is preferred.

- **Positions Available:**

- HR Operations Specialist
- Assistant HR Manager Intern
- HR & Talent Intern

5. Supply Chain

Sephora's Supply Chain department is responsible for maximizing product availability, optimizing inventory levels, managing replenishment strategies, and overseeing logistics operations. Sephora offers a variety of supply chain roles across retail stores, corporate offices, and distribution centers throughout Europe, with active recruitment in several countries including France, Italy, Germany, the UK, and Spain. Specifically, supply chain-related roles are frequently available in France, Germany, Poland, and the Nordics.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- **Supply Planner Europe** The Supply Planner Europe is responsible for purchasing commercial products from suppliers within an assigned budget. They manage order frequencies to optimize logistics costs within a complex remote sourcing environment spanning 3 warehouses and 15 countries. Key duties include securing inventory in warehouses in a timely manner, developing relationships with partner brands, and tracking and communicating KPIs with both internal and external stakeholders. They manage supplier procurement using various Incoterms and coordinate the procurement process for new brand or product launches. They are also responsible for validating logistics, finance, marketing, and quality-related matters, and managing core inventory parameters for the central warehouse. Additionally, they establish purchasing plans for year-end and special events and oversee product lifecycle management and regulatory compliance. Weekly operational tasks include entering supplier orders, tracking transportation, updating order dates, analyzing stock-outs or excess inventory, and implementing corrective actions. They ensure master data is updated based on supplier information, handle quantity and price disputes, and manage supplier returns.
- **Global Project Manager, Supply Chain** The Global Project Manager organizes, steers, and executes IT projects that support Sephora's upstream and downstream supply chain, logistics, and e-commerce strategies across an omnichannel environment in over 30 countries. This role includes overseeing service providers and vendors involved in IT project implementation, including migration projects to SAP S/4 HANA.
- **Assistant Demand & Supply Planner** The Assistant Demand & Supply Planner is responsible for tracking and confirming customer orders, providing visibility into inventory availability, and tracking orders for new products. They also track and manage inventory for specific product lines, ensure updates in tools like SAP, and monitor processes. They monitor new product launches, ensure delivery to each country, and centralize and share alerts when delays occur.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Candidates with higher education (Bachelor's +4/5) in Supply Chain or relevant experience are preferred.
- Broad expertise in logistics, third-party logistics (3PL) management, and demand and supply planning is required. Strong knowledge of planning systems/ERP (SAP and RELEX) is an asset. Excellent analytical skills, emotional intelligence, and communication skills are essential. The ability to work under pressure in a fast-paced environment is critical.
- Fluency in English is required, and for roles in Europe, proficiency in French is a strong advantage.
- Strong functional and technical expertise in SAP SD and MM modules is essential, along with knowledge of SAP ECC and SAP S/4 HANA environments. Excellent analytical and synthesis skills, teamwork, communication skills, and an interest in new technologies and innovation are important. Proficiency in Office tools (Excel, PowerPoint, PowerBI) and knowledge of ERP or EPM are considered strengths.

- **Positions Available:**

- Junior E-Commerce Logistics Specialist
- Forecast Analyst
- Distribution Planner
- Junior Buyer (Apprenticeship)
- Assistant Demand & Supply Planner EU
- Assistant Supply Chain Project Manager (Intern)
- Assistant Chef de Projets Supply Chain Global

6. IT (Information Technology)

The IT department supports the seamless and stable operation of retail systems, acts as the primary contact for IT-related issues, and bridges technology and business functions.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Supply Planner Europe The Supply Planner Europe is responsible for Support the smooth and stable operation of retail systems across the UK.
- Act as the primary contact for all IT-related issues.
- Identify opportunities for improvement and propose constructive and innovative changes.
- Effectively manage change processes driven by the group and adhere to best practices in project governance.
- Manage resources of local IT departments and be responsible for the annual national IT budget.
- Oversee the management and maintenance of company infrastructure and be responsible for fixed and mobile national networks.

- Supervise all helpdesk activities, including problem resolution and intervention, providing skilled support when needed.
- Maintain vendor relationships and manage local procurement of hardware and software products within group policies and international agreements.
- Bridge technology and business functions, focusing on finance, indirect procurement, and legal.
- Support the setup and activation of Global Governance for Enterprise Services.
- Define global technology strategies for functions (finance, procurement, and legal), validating direction through regular reviews with C-level and arbitrating priorities, scope, budget, timing, and resources.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- A Bachelor's degree in IT or a related field is required.
- Must possess strong IT infrastructure and operations management skills.
- Expertise in network administration, cybersecurity, and GDPR compliance is necessary.
- Excellent communication and problem-solving skills are required.
- Retail experience and project and change management experience are preferred.
- Experience in back-office application environments and expertise in SAP certification management are essential.
- Proficiency in enterprise architecture concepts and solution management from design to implementation is required.
- Familiarity with ERP, EPM, procurement, and data platform concepts is needed.
- Fluency in English is required, and local language is a plus.

- **Positions Available:**

- IT Engineer – Retail
- SAP Technical Assistant (Intern)
- Data Analyst
- Apprenticeship Data Analyst
- Alternance – Assistant Data Analyst IT
- Stage – Junior Project Manager IT
- IT Engineer – Retail

7. Finance

The Finance department ensures the reliability of financial data, leads budgeting processes, reports monthly net sales and profits, and manages key financial planning processes.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Ensure the reliability of financial data reported to LVMH.
- Report monthly net sales and profit to Sephora EME and Sephora Global.
- Lead budgeting processes and revisions, including setting timelines and raising budget issues.
- Manage and improve key financial planning processes.
- Drive the development of annual budgets, estimates, and forecasts.
- Perform the financial control role within the finance department.
- Act as a bridge between technology and business functions, focusing on finance, indirect procurement, and legal.
- Support the setup and activation of global governance, steering the demand portfolio for global initiatives.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Strong analytical and problem-solving skills are required.
- Knowledge and confidence in budget management, analysis, and daily reporting are important.
- Proficiency in Excel and PowerPoint is essential.
- Knowledge of finance, indirect procurement, and legal, and an understanding of the retail industry are preferred.
- Proven experience in cross-functional management, project portfolio management, and project management is important.
- Fluency in English is required, and local language is a plus.

- **Positions Available:**

- Finance BI Project Officer (CDI - Finance BI Project Officer)
- Finance Intern
- Global Finance Reporting Officer
- Junior Controller
- Junior Financial Analyst
- Finance Assistant
- Accounting Assistant

8. Merchandising

The Merchandising department is responsible for developing product assortment strategies, building supplier partnerships, analyzing market trends, and implementing in-store merchandising concepts.

- **Main Responsibilities:**

- Responsible for assortment strategy and the entire product lifecycle across retail and e-commerce.
- Build and develop strong supplier partnerships through business reviews and performance tracking.
- Analyze market trends, consumer behavior, sales data, and budgets to identify opportunities and risks.
- Drive merchandising concepts, floor plans, and localization for stores, corners, and new openings.
- Ensure high-quality execution of merchandising standards and continuous process improvement.
- Maximize product sales, optimize inventory availability, and support promotional activities.
- Comprehensively manage at least one of the four main product categories in-store (makeup, skincare, fragrance, Sephora Collection).
- Discover and manage new launches and brands, including 360° planning (store setup, pricing, promotions, communication, etc.).
- Lead and optimize beauty categories to drive sales growth and customer engagement.
- Drive category strategy and foster growth through brand partnerships and assortment curation.
- Develop and oversee assortments across in-store and digital channels, leading launch strategies, animation, and storytelling.

- **Main Qualifications Needed:**

- Strong understanding of product, brand, and trade marketing, as well as sales principles, is necessary.
- High analytical skills and advanced MS Office proficiency, particularly in Excel and PowerPoint, are important.
- Must possess a strategic mindset and an execution-driven approach.
- Strong communication skills (German and English) and organizational ability to succeed in a dynamic and agile environment are required.
- Must have a strong hands-on mentality to support category management teams.
- The ability to manage a brand portfolio, maximize sales, and ensure profitability and appropriate inventory management is required.

- **Positions Available:**

- Merchandising Intern
- Merchandising Operations Trainee
- Intern Category Management
- Visual Merchandising Assistant (Alternance - ASSISTANT VISUEL MERCHANDISING)

CAREER PROGRESSION

1. UNDERSTANDING CAREER GROWTH AT SEPHORA

At Sephora, there are many opportunities for career progression, but they are structured and conditional. Employees must take initiative and actively position themselves for growth, instead of expecting automatic promotion. At the same time, employees are encouraged to develop new skills through internal training programs, mentorships, and cross-departmental projects.

Across both retail and corporate roles, progression is influenced by both formal and informal factors:

- Consistent performance against KPIs and business targets
- Strong stakeholder or client portfolio management
- Alignment with Sephora's brand values and service standards
- Internal visibility and networking
- Role-specific expertise

Promotion and Compensation Process

Employees are typically assessed through annual performance reviews, which evaluate your individual contributions, alignment with company objectives, and readiness for promotion.

Salary adjustments and promotions typically follow a multi-step process:

1. Initial discussion with the direct manager
2. Review at the leadership level
3. "Calibration" discussions among Directors to ensure consistency across teams
4. Final decisions reported to and approved by Global HQ

Emerging Opportunities: The Rise of K-Beauty.

The growing global demand for K-beauty brings career opportunities for specific talent pools. An interviewer directly mentioned Sephora's plans to partner with Olive Young to bring Korean products to the European market. This creates potential advantages, in particular for Korean students, or those familiar with K-beauty trends and Asian beauty markets.

As the company continues to globalize its product assortment, cultural and market-specific expertise is becoming an increasingly valuable asset.

A Platform for Long-Term Career Development

Sephora should not be viewed only as a retail employer, but as a career platform within the global beauty and luxury ecosystem.

One key advantage of working at Sephora is exposure to a wide range of premium brands. An interviewee (Ludovica Brizio) quoted that "Most of the popular brands in Italy and Europe are Sephora exclusives."

This exposure creates valuable exit opportunities, especially for employees interested in transitioning into:

- Brand-side corporate roles (e.g., marketing, merchandising)
- Other companies within the beauty and cosmetics industry
- Roles within the broader LVMH ecosystem

As part of the LVMH group, Sephora also offers opportunities for regional and international mobility, including movement across markets and roles. While these opportunities are competitive and not guaranteed, they are a key long-term advantage of building a career within Sephora, which will be explored in more detail in the following sections.

2. PROGRESSION PATHWAYS

Career progression at Sephora does not happen through only one fixed route. Based on the research and interview insights, Sephora's career progression opportunities can be categorised into 3 main pathways:

- a. Store-based progression
- b. Corporate and cross-functional progression
- c. Regional / international mobility.

A) Store-Based Progression (Most Accessible Entry Point)

Store-based retail roles are one of the most accessible entry points into Sephora, especially for those who do not have direct experience in beauty or luxury. Although retail roles are often overlooked, they can help create a strong foundation because they provide direct exposure to customers, products, sales targets, and brand experience.

A Sephora Beauty Advisor in Italy explained that working at Sephora gives employees access to major beauty brands, and that employees have "many opportunities for growth" through Sephora's internal learning platform, including skincare education.

Step-by-Step Pathway:

- **Step 1: Enter through a store role**
 - Start as a Beauty Advisor or similar retail-level position. This allows employees to build product knowledge, customer service skills, and familiarity with Sephora's service standards and brand experience.
- **Step 2: Move into senior retail or leadership roles**
 - Based on external research, a possible structure is:
 - Beauty Advisor → Lead/Specialist → Assistant Manager → Store Director
 - Although this example comes from Louis Vuitton, it reflects how progression can work within LVMH retail environments.
- **Step 3: Use store experience as a leverage into corporate roles**

The following table shows an example of a career progression timeline at a Sephora store. However, timelines may vary greatly depending on stores, region, performance, and available openings, so please only use this as a general guide.

Role	Average Time in Role	Responsibilities to Master for Advancement
Beauty Advisor	1-2 Years	• Sales Goals • Client service • Brand knowledge • Loyalty
Lead / Specialist (Eg. Lead Beauty Advisor)	1-3 Years	• Peer mentoring • Zone ownership • Driving team metrics • Basic Operations
Assistant Manager	2-4 Years	• Team development • Performance Management • Store Operations • Scheduling
Store Director	Ongoing	• Full profit & loss responsibility • Talent strategy • Business Development

Case Study

Sephora posted a case of one of their employees, Ariana, who first started as a Beauty Advisor. She worked her way up into store leadership, and is now working as a Business Operations Manager at Sephora corporate HQ. Her role revolves around inventory management, loss prevention, and supporting overall store processes. This made her knowledge working on-site at the stores very valuable as she knew what the stores needed.

B) Corporate and Cross-Functional Progression

Corporate progression at Sephora is about building relevant expertise. According to our interview with Jay Kim, internal transfers are “quite free”, but they do not happen very often because each role requires specific expertise. However, it is much easier when the functions are related, for example, someone in marketing may move from branding to social viral marketing.

These transfers require internal discussions with People Managers, and will mostly start with a “soft landing” in which an employee will handle both their old and new positions first, before fully transitioning to the new position if they show strength in that area.

This means that corporate career growth is possible, but students should not assume that Sephora works like a generalist rotation system. The company appears to value people who have deep knowledge in their function and can contribute quickly.

C) Regional/International Mobility (Moving Across Markets and LVMH)

One of Sephora's strongest long-term career advantages is its connection to LVMH. LVMH encourages international mobility, which means that Sephora employees are able to move across countries, regions, and even between the different brands under the LVMH group.

This pathway is especially important for students interested in Europe because Sephora can serve as an entry point into the wider global luxury and beauty ecosystem. However, international mobility is not automatic. It requires strong performance, internal networking, and clear communication about relocation goals.

This is the most suitable pathway for students who may also be interested in other brands under the LVMH group, especially luxury brands that are usually more closed off, such as Dior and Louis Vuitton. Other candidates who may benefit from this pathway are those who are curious about working and living in other countries where LVMH operates. However, international mobility is not automatic. It requires strong performance, internal networking, and clear communication about relocation goals.

Step-by-Step Pathway:

- **Step 1: Build a strong track record in your current role**
 - International transfers require proof that the employee has performed well and can adapt to a different market.
- **Step 2: Make mobility interests visible**
 - One Sephora case study showed that the employee updated her internal "My Sephora Career" profile to reflect the countries she was open to relocating to.
- **Step 3: Talk to the right internal partners**
 - The same case emphasised the importance of being vocal and speaking with the right people.
 - Another employee advised that networking is key, especially cross-functionally within Sephora and LVMH.
- **Step 4: Enter internal mobility discussions**
 - In one case, the employee's candidacy was discussed during a Global Mobility session before she moved to Australia.
- **Step 5: Transfer across country, region, or function**
 - Successful employees may move to new regional offices, global roles, or training/leadership positions across Sephora and LVMH.

Case Studies

Case 1: Michelle Boeve (Transferred to France)

- Previously: Executive Assistant Merchandising in San Francisco (USA)
- Now: CEO of Sephora Collection in Paris (France)

→ She attended a session during Careerfest about International Mobility within LVMH

Case 2: Stacy Paoa (Transferred to Australia and New Zealand)

- Previously: Senior District Manager in East Bay and Hawaii (USA)
- Now: Director of Stores and Client Experience of Sephora in Australia and New Zealand

→ She had been with Sephora for 15 years before wanting to expand outside of the US market. She updated her “My Sephora Career website” to show the countries she was interested in, before getting a call from her Regional Direction about the opportunity in Australia. Her candidature was later discussed at a Global Mobility session.

Case 3: Elizabeth Crawford (Transferred to Dubai)

- Previously: Manager of Learning & Development at San Francisco (USA)
- Now: Sephora University Director at Sephora Middle East (based in Dubai but oversee trainings for: UAE, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, & Saudi Arabia)
- Tips:
 - Network cross-functionally inside the company (Sephora & LVMH),
 - Introduce yourself to international employees when they are in town for meetings.
 - Share your interest with your manager.

Case 4: Heather Smith

- Previously: Store Director of Embarcadero in San Francisco, CA
- Now: Client Experience Training Manager — Sephora Europe & Middle East (Paris, France)

3. EARLY CAREER ENTRY POINTS: INTERNSHIPS & GRADUATE PATHWAYS

Entering Sephora, especially in the European market, does not follow a single standardized pathway. Entry points vary by region, with notable differences between the U.S., which offers more structured programs, and Europe, which is more internship-driven.

Understanding this distinction is critical for students, as it directly shapes how they should prepare.

A) Europe (Internship-Driven Entry)

In the European market, and particularly in France, early-career hiring within Sephora and the broader LVMH, is influenced by the structure of Master's programs.

Many Master's programs in France require students to complete internships, apprenticeships, or work-study programs. As a result, companies often rely on these roles as their primary entry pipeline, rather than hiring directly into full-time junior positions.

Based on interview insights about the LVMH ecosystem:

- Entry-level roles are often filled through interns or apprentices rather than external hires
- Teams may rely on interns for ongoing support rather than immediately converting them into full-time employees
- It is common for one intern to be replaced by another at the end of a contract

However, this insight is based on the broader LVMH ecosystem in France and may vary by brand. Nevertheless, students should keep this in mind to tailor their approach to the European job market. Internships are not just an optional experience, as they are often the main entry point into the industry.

B) Reference: U.S. Structured Programs

In contrast to Europe, Sephora's U.S. market offers more structured early-career programs. While these may not be directly transferable to Europe, they provide a useful reference for understanding how Sephora develops talent and what it expects from strong candidates.

Internship Program

Sephora's U.S. internship program typically includes:

- 10-12 week period
 - Majority of it may be remote, with a one-week onsite experience at the San Francisco office).
- Project-based work (e.g., marketing campaigns, product launches, store optimisation, supply chain initiatives)
- Networking opportunities and skill-building workshops
- Exposure to cross-functional teams

Some things to notes are:

- These programs often open nearly a year in advance, so students must prepare early
- High-performing interns may be considered for full-time roles, with some programs reporting conversion rates of approximately 60-70%.



LEAP Program

Sephora's LEAP Program (Learn. Engage. Aspire. Path.) is a 10-month cross-functional program designed to launch your career at Sephora corporate. Trainees are rotated across 3 core business areas, and receive practical training modules and tailored mentorship.

Students who completed the Internship Program mentioned above also have the chance to apply to the LEAP program during their internship.



Sephora Store Leadership Development Program

This is not strictly an 'internship', but an entry point for those interested in retail operations and management. It is a more structured version of the store-based career pathway, accelerating progression into leadership roles.

The program:

- Targets recent graduates (within 2 years of graduation)
- Lasts apprx. 6-12 months
- Focuses on developing:
 - Team leadership
 - Store operations
 - Inventory management
 - Client service

INTERVIEW & RECRUITMENT PROCESS

Sephora's recruitment process varies significantly depending on the role, department, seniority level, and region. However, most candidates can expect a core process with some variation based on function and seniority. The core process presented below will be based on entry-level jobs and internships.

Formal applications (outside of informal networking opportunities) may be submitted through Sephora's career portal or the broader LVMH job platform.

Parts of the application process may be supported by AI-assisted screening tools, but final hiring decisions are made by recruiters and hiring managers.

1. CORE RECRUITMENT PROCESS:

- **Step 1: Application and Document Screening**
 - CV + Cover Letter (sometimes)
- **Step 2: HR Screening**
 - May include a phone/video interview (20-30 mins)
 - Conversation with a recruiter to discuss your background, interest in Sephora, and basic behavioral questions.
 - Tip: Prepare 2-3 questions about the program to show initiative + interest
- **Step 3: Interviews with Hiring Team**
 - Interviews with hiring managers, team members, or department representatives
 - Will focus on your skills, motivation, cultural fit
- **Step 4: Assessment or Task (Role-Dependent)**
 - This is not always required, but may include:
 - Case studies
 - Technical tasks (e.g., Excel tests for analytics roles)
 - Situational judgment tests
 - Customer or service-based scenarios
- **Step 5: Final Decision**
 - Acceptance offer or rejection

2. WHAT SEPHORA IS ACTUALLY EVALUATING

Sephora places strong emphasis on the following areas:

- **Customer and Service Mindset**
 - Even for non-retail roles, candidates are expected to understand customer needs, service quality, and client interaction.

- **Teamwork and Cultural Fit**

- Ability to work with people from different backgrounds, manage conflict with coworkers, contribute to a collaborative environment

- **Initiative and Problem-Solving**

- Willingness to try new ideas, ability to handle challenges, ownership of tasks and outcomes

- **Sales and Performance Awareness**

- Especially relevant for retail and leadership roles
- Sales experience, understanding of KPIs and targets, ability to drive performance

3. SAMPLE INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

The following sample questions are based on insights from individuals who have experienced the Sephora interview process. They are organised by category, and represent the types of behavioural questions candidates may be asked.

- **Customer and Service**

- → *Tests your communication style, emotional intelligence, and ability to deliver a positive customer experience.*
 - Describe a time you dealt with a difficult or upset customer. How did you handle it?
 - Tell me about a situation where a customer's needs were unclear. How did you clarify and respond?
 - Describe a time you had to work with a customer who was very different from you.

- **Teamwork and Interpersonal Skills**

- Describe a time you worked with people from different backgrounds or cultures.
- Tell me about a difficult situation with a coworker or manager. How did you handle it?
- Describe a conflict within your team and how you resolved it.

- **Initiative and Problem-Solving**

- → *Tests your ability to take action, adapt, handle uncertainty, and think creatively.*
 - Describe a time you tried something completely new.
 - Describe a situation where you faced a major obstacle. How did you overcome it?
 - Tell me about a time you tried an unusual idea that ended up working.

- **Sales & Performance (Retail-Focused Roles)**

- → *In retail or sales-specific corporate roles, sales experience is often prioritized over product knowledge.*

- Tell me about your previous experience with sales targets or KPIs.
- Have you worked in a high-volume store environment?
- What were your store's goals (e.g., sales, loyalty programs, credit cards)?
- How do you approach achieving sales targets?

- **Leadership & Management**

- → *More common for leadership roles, tests your ability to manage performance and support employee development.*
 - Tell me about a time you had to deal with a difficult employee.
 - What is the biggest challenge you have faced as a manager?
 - How would you describe your management or leadership style?
 - Describe your experience coaching or motivating others.

- **Role Fit & Experience**

- → *Assesses your background, tests if your experience is directly transferable to the role.*
 - Tell me about your previous work experience and how it relates to this role.
 - What experience do you have in customer service, sales, or supervising others?
 - How have your past roles prepared you for this position?

- **Commitment & Availability (Retail Roles)**

- Are you available to work nights, weekends, and holidays?
- How long do you plan to stay in this role?

HOW STUDENTS CAN PREPARE

Preparation should be approached strategically, focusing not only on qualifications, but also on fit, positioning, and long-term career planning.

1. Understand the Sephora Experience and Brand Mindset

One interviewee highlighted that employees are trained through programs such as **“Sephora Attitude”**, which standardizes how employees interact with customers and represent the brand.

This means that students should:

- Learn how Sephora defines customer experience
- Understand how employees communicate with clients
- Observe how products are recommended and positioned

Candidates should also be able to tailor their communication style depending on the customer. Some customers prefer quick, efficient recommendations, while others expect more prolonged and conversational interactions.

Even for corporate roles, understanding this dynamic is important, as Sephora is a customer-driven business, and one of their key differentiators is the store experience that customers have when they are buying products. Another interviewee also highlighted the importance of psychology, which reflects the need for emotional intelligence and client awareness.

2. Build Experience Even Without Direct Access

Though the beauty and luxury industry can be relatively closed and hard to break into, there are still indirect ways for students to build transferrable skills or to show genuine interest in the industry, which will make employers more open to the idea of hiring you.

Build experience in areas such as:

- Retail or customer service (especially in beauty or fashion)
- Marketing or social media (e.g., managing campaigns or content)
- Leadership roles (e.g., student organizations, team projects)
- Consulting, case competitions, or business-related projects

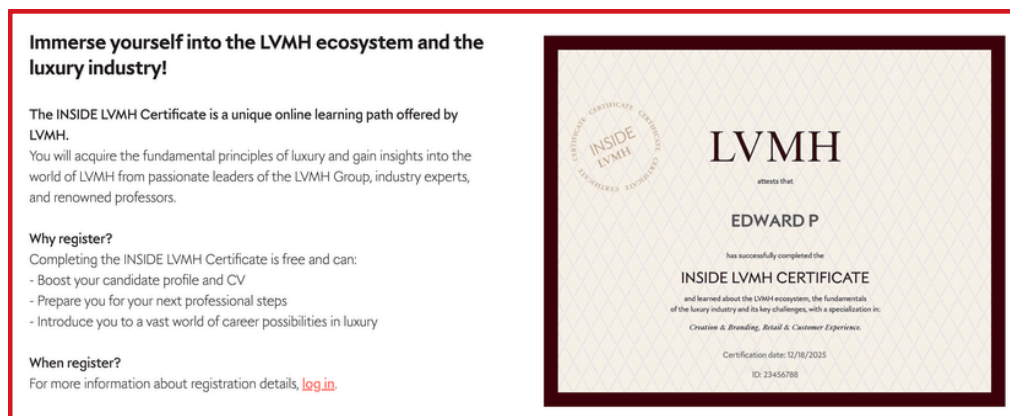
Inside Tip! (Online Certifications)

Students can take advantage of online courses, such as the **“Inside LVMH Certificate”**. This was directly recommended by one of our interviewees, and is an 8-week program that teaches you the fundamentals of the luxury industry and how LVMH operates. You get to learn from industry experts and renowned professors through a combination of courses, cases, and quizzes.

Though this course is not specific to Sephora, it is still highly relevant because:

- Sephora operates within the LVMH ecosystem
- It provides insight into the premium and higher-end beauty and luxury market
- It helps students understand how brands, retail, and corporate functions interact
- It will help students show that they have a genuine interest in the industry, the initiative to learn independently, and the willingness to invest time and effort beyond academic requirements

In a competitive and relationship-driven industry, these can help candidates stand out, especially when they lack direct experience.



3. Develop Well-Rounded Skills

Keep in mind that the specific skills required will depend on the role, but there are several core competencies that will prove useful in various roles.

Hard Skills

- Data analysis (Excel, Tableau, Power BI)
- Digital marketing (social media, content creation, SEO/SEM)
- Project management tools (e.g., Asana, Monday.com)
- Technical skills (for digital roles: Python, JavaScript, e-commerce platforms)
- Basic financial literacy (P&L, ROI, budgeting)

Soft Skills

- Client-centric thinking
- Adaptability in fast-paced environments
- Collaboration across teams and functions
- Managing conflict and ambiguity
- Creativity and problem-solving
- Cultural awareness in global teams

4. Build a Strong Portfolio (Especially for Corporate Roles)

A portfolio can significantly strengthen applications for roles in marketing, digital, or analytics.

Strong portfolios typically include:

- 3-5 curated projects
- Social media campaigns with measurable results
- Marketing or design work
- Data analysis projects with visualizations
- Written content on beauty trends or consumer behavior

Tips:

- Host the portfolio on platforms like Notion, Wix, or personal websites
- Clearly explain each project (context, approach, outcomes)
- Focus on quality over quantity

5. Demonstrate Genuine Interest in Beauty

One of the most consistent insights from our interviews is that the beauty industry is closed and passion-driven. It is filled with people who already have a deep, pre-existing interest in beauty, therefore just saying that you “like beauty products” is not enough.

This is especially important because Sephora is both a retailer and a brand owner (Sephora Collection), therefore they have to keep up with products, trends, and consumer behaviour on multiple fronts.

Students should:

- Stay updated on beauty trends and product launches
- Follow brands, influencers, and industry news
- Understand different product categories and terminology
 - One interviewee highlighted that major issue many new employees face is the terminology, since beauty has its own set of industry terms that differ from fashion.

6. Network

Networking is one of the most important factors in entering the industry, especially in the context of the European job market. Many roles are filled through connections and referrals, and is often a key differentiator in securing opportunities.

Students should:

- Build relationships with peers, alumni, and professionals
 - In Europe, there are less structured opportunities (eg. team dinners) to network with your colleagues. They much prefer more informal interactions such as going for coffee or having casual conversations.
- Engage in industry events or programs



4. INTERVIEW WITH PROFESSIONALS

Jay Kim

*Former Senior Manager & Director of
eCommerce at Sephora Korea*

Seou Choi

*Merchandising Manager at Thélios France
(LVMH eyewear division)*

Ludovica Brizio

Beauty Advisor at Sephora Italy

Yelyzaveta Shtanko

*Trade Marketing Assistant at Thélios France
(LVMH eyewear division)*

Ilaria Brizio

*Former Sales Associate at Louis Vuitton
Monaco*

INTRODUCTION

This section presents insights gathered from interviews with professionals who are working/have worked across Sephora and the broader LVMH ecosystem.

These individuals represent a range of roles across retail, corporate, and related luxury sectors. While all of the companies fall under the LVMH group, the interviews highlight that the beauty industry and other luxury sectors can operate quite differently in terms of structure, pace, and career pathways. These differences are still useful for students as a point of comparison to better understand their own fit within these industries and to gain a broader perspective on how the LVMH ecosystem operates. They should be understood as providing general guidance on the European job market and how it may translate to Sephora and the beauty industry.

It is also important to note that industry practices may vary significantly by region. Corporate beauty roles in Asia and Europe, for example, may differ in terms of structure, culture, and hiring pathways. Most of our interviewees are based in Europe, with the exception of the former Director of eCommerce at Sephora Korea. As such, these insights should be understood as general guidance rather than fixed rules, and may differ depending on local context.

A key value of these interviews lies in their ability to provide direct and unfiltered perspectives on the industry. Unlike publicly available information, which often highlights only the most visible and official aspects of global brands, these insights reflect the realities of working in the field. Interviewees openly discussed challenges such as the competitive and “closed” nature of the industry, the importance of prior experience, and the role of networking in securing opportunities. These insights are extremely valuable for students, especially those based outside of Europe. While building connections in a different region may be difficult, the interviews also demonstrate that networking can take many forms, including referrals, alumni connections, and informal conversations.

Sales Associate interviews were also included despite the fact that they are not corporate roles because they provide insight into one of the most realistic entry points for applicants without prior experience. They help show what it can actually look like to begin a career in beauty from the ground up.

Overall, this section complements the research by offering a more nuanced understanding of how careers in Sephora and LVMH develop in practice. Rather than providing a single definitive pathway, these interviews highlight both the challenges and the strategies that can help students navigate the industry more effectively.



Jay Kim

Former Senior Manager & Director of eCommerce at Sephora Korea

**This interview has been translated from Korean to English, therefore minor variations in wording may occur.*

***Interview insights may be specific to the Korean or APAC region.*

Q: What is a typical daily routine for a Sephora professional? What are the "Core Tasks" that take up the largest portion of your work?

A: The core tasks vary depending on the position, but the primary focus across all regions was driving sales growth and strengthening brand presence. Regarding the daily routine, the workload is generally split into **70% local business operations and 30% global collaboration**. As Sephora Korea is part of the APAC region, our systems and tasks were closely linked with the Regional HQ in Singapore. While actual decision-making happened in Korea, we collaborated continuously with the global team to leverage their established experience within the APAC market.

Q: Could you share a project example that illustrates the complexity and dynamism of the work, beyond what is mentioned in the Job Description?

A: While launching any new business is challenging, we often faced unexpected issues specific to the local region. For the launch of the Sephora mobile app, the initial JD-based plan was to localize the existing global version. However, **due to unique Korean market requirements (user registration, payment systems, logistics, etc.), localization hit a wall**. We had to reset the project midway and start from scratch. This required persuading the global team, scouting a local development team, and navigating constant variables from planning to launch to ensure we met global standards while satisfying local needs. It was a process of simultaneous development and global persuasion, which led to frequent "resets" during the implementation stages. Additionally, aiming for a simultaneous "omnichannel" launch (opening offline and online stores at the same time)—a first for Sephora globally—led to many unforeseen variables.

Q: What differentiates the way a "Global Multi-Brand Retailer" like Sephora operates compared to "Single-Brand" companies (eg. manufacturers, distributors, etc.)?

A: Single-brand distribution focuses heavily on production dependency rather than sourcing. In contrast, a **multi-brand retailer functions more as a platform, where product sourcing, price negotiation, inventory management, and sales consultations play a much larger role.** Since Sephora acts as both a retailer and a brand owner (Sephora Collection), it was crucial to achieve two goals: **providing fair promotional opportunities to maintain stable partnerships while simultaneously driving overall revenue growth.**

Q: What are common misconceptions job seekers have about this role, or "hidden realities" one only learns after joining?

A: Like any other job, there is a fantasy regarding the visible results. Especially with global companies, people focus on the "glamorous" side, such as business trips and communicating with foreigners. In reality, there were many days where we worked more than 12 hours. Due to time zone differences, work often extends beyond standard Korean office hours*, and since public holidays differ by country, work tends to occupy most of the day, even while on vacation.

****This insight is based on the Korean market and may reflect region-specific working conditions.***

Q: How does cross-functional collaboration happen within Sephora? Which departments did your team communicate with most closely?

A: Collaboration is conducted through Slack and Confluence. The Digital team needed to communicate with almost every part of the organization, but we worked most closely with Merchandising, CS, Logistics, and CRM.

Q: When hiring, which do you prioritize: light experience at a large global corporation versus an impactful, hands-on experience at a startup or smaller organization?

A: It depends on the company's stage and the specific task. For a new business launch, a "generalist" strength is often more necessary than specialized expertise, similar to a startup environment. Large corp employees usually have a high understanding of processes and can solve assigned tasks with high density, but they can sometimes be slow to respond to unexpected tasks or areas outside their specific domain. **Sephora generally favors those from large beauty corporations**—specifically people who have deep expertise but have also handled a diverse range of tasks.

Q: What "culture shocks" or "unwritten rules" do new hires who are unfamiliar with global corporate culture often face?

A: The biggest challenge is language. In the APAC region, there are many Asian speakers, so **you must become accustomed to various Asian English accents rather than just standard English.** Culturally, unlike some Korean companies, **there is a strict rule against mentioning race or personal preferences.** An unwritten rule is to follow global processes as much as possible while modifying them to fit the Korean market. Internally, we used a mix of English and Korean, and since most employees had prior global experience, there weren't many issues. However, **those only familiar with traditional Korean corporate environments might find the foreign process flow somewhat awkward.**

Q: Are there any experiences that can make a candidate stand out when applying for this role, even if it is not directly related to one's major?

A: **A genuine passion for beauty,** curiosity about diverse products, and a high level of interest in social media and trending news are very important.

Q: What is the biggest gap you see in new hires who lack a fashion or beauty background, and how can they realistically overcome this before applying?

A: The **biggest issue is terminology.** Beauty has its own set of industry terms that differ from fashion, some of which are used as global standards. If you are not familiar with these, communication costs increase. Since this is hard to cover purely through pre-entry study, we typically provide internal training and share a glossary of terms after the hire joins.

Q: For those who successfully pivoted to Sephora from a different industry, what were their common strengths or preparation processes?

A: I was one of those cases. Key strengths include **deep expertise in your specific function, flexibility toward different industries, and the ability to transfer your existing experience into a new market.**

Q: How do internal transfers or career development usually occur?

A: **Internal transfers are relatively free, but they don't happen very often because each role requires specific expertise.** For example, in Marketing, a person handling branding might move to social viral marketing.

This is managed through discussions with People Managers, starting with a "soft landing" where the employee handles both roles before fully transitioning if they show strength in the new area. At Sephora, **moving from the Korean branch to APAC HQ is also flexible; many who proved their expertise in Korea eventually moved to the Regional HQ in Singapore.**

Q: Is it easier to transfer departments compared to other companies?

A: It is more difficult than at typical large conglomerates. Because **many roles require specialized expertise and the company focuses on hiring experienced professionals, it isn't "easy."** However, it is certainly possible if you demonstrate the will and the capability.

Q: How are the performance review cycles and the resulting compensation/salary adjustments structured?

A: The performance review cycle is annual. Regarding salary adjustments, you first have a primary discussion with your direct manager. Then, the Directors meet for a "calibration" discussion, and the final decision is made after reporting to the Global HQ.

Q: If there is one piece of advice or insight you wish you had known before entering this industry, what would it be?

A: The beauty industry is more "closed" than others. It is filled with people who have a deep, pre-existing love for beauty. Therefore, you need more than just a desire to switch industries; you need a genuine passion for the field and the certainty that you truly love this industry.



Seou Choi

Merchandising Manager at Thélios France (LVMH eyewear division)

[Former] EMEA Trade Marketing & Sales Assistant at Estée Lauder Companies Inc.

[Former] Business Development Assistant (Dolce & Gabbana) at Shiseido

Q: Could you briefly walk us through your journey so far, and how you ended up in your current role at Thélios?

A: I grew up in the UK and France, so I was already familiar with the language and environment. I completed my undergraduate degree at Yonsei University (UIC, International Studies), then pursued a Master's in Management at ESSEC Business School in France, which has strong connections to the luxury industry. During my Master's, I completed two internships, one at Shiseido and another at Estée Lauder, where I worked in business development and trade marketing. Through these experiences, I realized that the beauty industry was not the right fit for me. After graduating, I joined Thélios as an intern and received a return offer for a full-time role, and I have now been working here for four years.

Q: Why did you choose the luxury fashion industry over the beauty industry?

A: I chose the luxury industry because I prefer a slower and more structured work environment. **The beauty industry is very fast-paced, highly consumer-facing, and involves a large volume of products** (eg. one lipstick may have 25 varieties of colours) and frequent launches, which can be overwhelming. In contrast, luxury eyewear has only 3 product launches per year and much longer development cycles (up to 1.5 years for a single pair of glasses), which allows me to focus more on the detail, craftsmanship, and technical aspects. I also value the better work-life balance that comes with this type of work.

Q: What does your day actually look like in your role, and what responsibilities take up most of your time? Can you share an example of a project that reflects the real complexity of your role, beyond the usual job descriptions?

A: As a Merchandising Manager, around **60% of my work is focused on data analysis**, particularly tracking sales performance across different

markets. I work within the global **product strategy** team and right under the Chief Product Officer, so I help define product assortment and release plans across multiple brands under LVMH, such as Dior and Fendi. My role is more **B2B-focused**, meaning I work with retailers and wholesalers to acquire licensing agreements, rather than directly controlling what goes into individual stores. On a daily basis, I analyze monthly sales data, prepare long-term product release plans, and conduct ad hoc analysis for different regions. I also work on cross-brand strategy, deciding on product volume, distribution, and positioning.

Q: How does working in a global company affect your role and responsibilities?

A: I work at the **global headquarters level, which focuses more on strategy and branding, while regional teams are responsible for adapting products to local markets.** In luxury companies, decisions are very top-down because brand consistency is extremely important. My role involves working with confidential data and contributing to long-term planning, including future product releases. While working at **HQ gives me more exposure to strategy**, it also means I have less direct control over what happens in specific markets.

Q: Looking at your current role, what skills do you use most that you didn't expect to be so important?

A: While I use technical skills like data analysis frequently, I found that **interpersonal skills are even more important than I expected.** Building strong relationships with colleagues across teams helps make collaboration smoother, especially when dealing with delays as people are more willing to help you if they like you. People, and also the HR department, notice how engaged or withdrawn you are within the company. **Even if you are introverted, it helps to still maintain connections with people in the team**, just by simply turning up and meeting people outside a work setting. **It is very different from the Korean corporate atmosphere. There are no official 회식s or team dinners; they prioritise more informal interactions** such as attending social events or having casual conversations.

Q: For students who don't necessarily have a background in luxury or fashion, what are the most important things they can do to break into roles like yours? Have you seen people successfully transition into this

industry from unrelated backgrounds?

A: It is quite difficult to enter the luxury industry without relevant experience, so I would recommend gaining exposure through **internships or part-time roles, especially in retail**. This helps demonstrate your interest in the industry and gives you experience interacting with customers. If you are looking to come in from a different industry, consulting roles will still allow you to pivot to more senior and strategic roles, but marketing and creative roles are more difficult to break into. **If you want to work in Europe, studying there can also help with visa issues** and networking opportunities. In general, it is difficult to switch into luxury without prior experience unless you enter through **structured pathways like Master's programs**.

Q: What differences have you observed between European and Korean work culture?

A: In Europe, the work environment is generally less hierarchical and more flexible, and I can communicate directly with senior managers. **Because Thélíos is still young and growing, there are also more opportunities for early promotions** and taking on broader responsibilities at a younger stage in one's career. There is also a stronger emphasis on efficiency and results rather than time spent in the office. Employees are given more flexibility, including remote work options and flexible schedules, and there is a clear focus on work-life balance. For example, **companies often have long holiday periods**, such as two weeks off in the summer and one week in the winter where the entire company basically shuts down and no one works. In some cases, teams may even take longer breaks during off-season periods. While this supports well-being, it can sometimes create challenges for regional teams if urgent issues arise while the headquarters is on leave.

Another difference is in career progression and compensation. **In France, it is relatively difficult to significantly increase your salary within the same company, so many professionals change jobs and companies every few years** to advance their careers. Early in one's career, people often move between companies every 2-4 years to improve compensation, then **they will stay longer once they reach more senior roles**. The **beauty industry tends to offer higher salaries**, while the luxury industry offers stronger brand value and better work-life balance. Because many people are attracted to luxury brands, salary negotiation can be more difficult in this field. I also received advice that career development can be compared to an "accordion." **Large companies provide structure, stability, and strong brand value, while smaller or growing companies offer more**

hands-on experience, broader responsibilities, and faster career progression. Moving between these types of environments can help build a more balanced and flexible career path over time.

Q: Since you started as an intern, what are the full-time conversion opportunities like at Thélios?

A: Full-time conversion opportunities depend heavily on the company's situation and timing. I was able to secure a full-time role at Thelios because the company was expanding rapidly at the time. When I joined, most interns were converted into full-time roles. However, this is not always the case. In more established brands like Dior, it is much harder to secure a full-time position unless there is an open role, such as when someone leaves the team. **In many cases, conversion also depends on your manager. If your manager values your work and the team needs additional support, they may push HR to create a position for you.** However, if the team is already full or the market conditions are not favorable, it becomes much more difficult, and outcomes can depend largely on timing and luck.

Language skills can also influence opportunities. Speaking French or Italian can increase your chances, especially when applying externally. However, **if you have already interned at the company and demonstrated strong performance, there may be more flexibility even if you do not fully meet all the formal requirements.** Networking also plays an important role, as it is generally easier to secure opportunities if you already have connections within the company.

For international candidates, it is often easier to enter through the beauty side of the business, as it has more regional roles and is more closely connected to local markets. In contrast, the luxury side tends to focus more on global strategy, making it more difficult for foreigners to enter, especially at the headquarters level. However, this can vary by brand, as some teams are more international while others are more culturally concentrated.

Q: From your experience, which roles offer the best learning opportunities early in a career?

A: Early in your career, the most important factor is not just the role itself, but the manager you work under. **Your direct manager can significantly shape your learning experience and career trajectory,** especially if they are well-connected and actively support your development.

In terms of roles, **positions such as corporate strategy or chief of staff can be valuable if you want a broader understanding of the business**, while marketing roles can be beneficial if you are more interested in the creative side and understanding processes.

Q: Is there anything you would do differently during your student years if your goal was to enter LVMH?

A: Looking back, I would approach my career with a more **flexible mindset**. Initially, I was focused on the beauty industry and did not specifically aim to enter LVMH or luxury. However, I realized that career paths are often shaped by experience, and it is important not to be too fixed on a specific role or brand from the beginning. **Instead of focusing on a single target, it is more effective to take incremental steps that bring you closer to the industry, even if they are not exactly what you initially envisioned.** For example, if your goal is to work at a brand like Dior, starting in a related role, such as working in a store or within a subsidiary, can still be a valuable entry point. Over time, as you gain more exposure, you develop a clearer understanding of your interests and can adjust your direction accordingly.



Ludovica Brizio

Beauty Advisor at Sephora Italy

Q: Why specifically did you choose to work at Sephora, instead of other beauty companies?

A: When it comes to Western brands and trends within Italy, most people associate high quality and rapid growth with Sephora. Most of the popular brands in Italy and Europe are Sephora exclusives. And **a lot of brands that I would love to work with in the future are at Sephora, which is why I chose to work here.**

Q: From what I understand, there are no major competitors with Sephora within Italy. Would you say this statement is mostly correct?

A: Yes, that is correct. Douglas is becoming more popular, but it is not as beloved or well-known as Sephora. In terms of local brands, Kiko is a local competitor, but they are more catered towards the young 'hip' generation, while Sephora has brands like Chanel, Dior, and luxury brands. Italian Youth (ages 16-25/30) are majorly into American brands that Sephora exclusively carries.

Q: I see- it seems that the situation with Sephora is parallel to the hold Olive Young has in Korea right now.

A: Yes, that is quite accurate. In terms of pricing, Olive Young is more affordable, but right now **KBeauty in Italy and Europe has exploded. Sephora is actually partnering with Olive Young to bring over Korean skincare**- Aestura and Laneige are already here, and Torriden is coming later this year. The two brands are going to merge together.

Q: Are there any odd benefits/ something you think Sephora does right?

A: There are 2 main things: **Sephora shows care for its workers.** Both when it comes to gifting products, and rewards for hitting KPI goals. You are really incentivized to work hard and appreciated for the job that you do. But also, regarding contracts, everything is perfectly laid out; there are strict policies on time off, overtime qualifications, compensation, etc.

Bureaucracy, documents, and employee benefits are better even compared to other jobs in Italy. Also, you have many opportunities for growth—there is a platform where you can learn about skincare.

Q: What does your day look like in your role, and what responsibilities take up most of your time?

A: I spent most of my time **restocking and serving clients**. We get shipped new products on Wednesday/Friday, and then we reorganize and catalog everything. But the major responsibility is serving clients. **Compared to Korea, where everyone does their own thing, people in Italy love to get advice and recommendations from workers.** A lot of my day is spent talking to clients.

Q: What skills or qualities are most important for succeeding in your department, beyond what is written in job descriptions?

A: The most important thing is **code switching**—being able to adapt to how to speak to people and their age. Some people want a very efficient recommendation and want to buy things as fast as possible, while others may want to chitchat! It is important to recognize what type of person is in front of you.

Q: How does working in a global or multi-brand company change the way your team works, compared to a more traditional single-brand company?

A: Since Sephora headquarters are originally French, the experience is not the same as Sephora in the US. The system with product returns/loyalty cards is all different. However, American influence has transferred over in the terms of customer service. **Sephora customer service is more proactive than a usual Italian or European company, which may be more of an American influence.**

Q: What are some unwritten rules or cultural norms that new hires usually struggle to adapt to, if any?

A: It is not written anywhere, but there are **courses on Sephora Attitude**—what is expected of you and how you should be speaking to people is a standardized process.



Yelyzaveta Shtanko

*Trade Marketing Assistant at Thélios France
(LVMH eyewear division)*

Q: Could you briefly walk us through your journey so far, and how you ended up in your current role at Thélios?

A: I completed my undergraduate degree at Yonsei University, majoring in Communication. After graduating, I worked for two years in Korea as a music marketing manager in the entertainment industry. I later transitioned into the eyewear industry, starting as a freelancer and eventually becoming a full-time e-commerce and marketing operator at a Korean eyewear brand. My involvement in this industry actually began during my freshman year, when I worked at a showroom in Hongdae. Over time, I built relationships within the company and gradually moved into roles in the global department. I am currently working at Thélios as part of my MBA program in France.

Most of my career opportunities came through networking rather than formal applications. For example, I was introduced to my first showroom role through a friend, and I later connected with professionals through casual conversations and coffee chats. I never directly applied to LVMH; when I made plans to go to France for my Masters, I reached out to Professor Tae, and she introduced me to a Yonsei alumnus who was in France, and she recommended me to the recruiter.

Q: What does your day look like in your role, and what responsibilities take up most of your time?

A: Trade marketing is very different from regular marketing. My role is mainly focused on project management at the headquarters level, where I am part of the decision-making team rather than working on regional execution. I manage global trade marketing projects, particularly for Dior eyewear, where I evaluate proposals from regional teams and decide whether they should move forward. If approved, I oversee the entire process, from design and production to final implementation, acting as the link between the brand, regional teams, clients (such as department stores or opticians), designers, and suppliers.

Each project is quite complex and long-term. I typically handle around **70 to 100 projects per year related to permanent retail fixtures**, which usually remain in place for about three years. Each project can take anywhere from 4 to 6 months or longer to complete, and I am responsible for managing it throughout the entire lifecycle, including ongoing maintenance after installation. The process **requires strong coordination**, as I need to communicate constantly with multiple stakeholders and ensure that everything is delivered on time and aligned with the brand's standards.

On a daily basis, my schedule is very meeting-heavy, with around 5 to 7 meetings each day. I start by receiving project briefs, then monitor progress, coordinate between teams, and report updates to the maison before launching the final output. I also play a key role in controlling the launch phase, ensuring that everything is executed correctly.

In terms of my autonomy as an intern, my experience is somewhat unique because I am replacing a senior manager, so I have been given a higher level of responsibility than typical interns. However, autonomy can vary depending on the team. For example, in Dior, there is less flexibility because final decisions must go through the maison, requiring multiple layers of approval. In contrast, some other brands may have more internal decision-making power and therefore more flexibility.

Q: What challenges have you faced as an international candidate, particularly regarding visa and language barriers?

A: As an international candidate, both visa and language barriers are significant challenges. I was fortunate that I secured my first full-time position in Korea relatively quickly after graduation, since it was actually the first interview I ever had. However, after that, I experienced a much more difficult job search, especially when the market conditions worsened. I applied to many roles and tailored my resume for each position, but rejections were common. It can be easy to feel discouraged or desperate in that situation, but **I chose to shift my approach toward networking instead.**

One key difference I noticed is that **in Korea, it is generally more straightforward to apply directly to jobs, whereas in France, the process is much more dependent on networking.** I would say it is about 50/50 between applications and referrals, and many of my classmates secured their jobs through connections rather than formal applications. Building genuine relationships became a crucial strategy for me.

Language is another major barrier. While my Korean is relatively strong, my French is not at the same level, which made the job search more challenging. In fact, the role I applied for initially required French speakers. However, I was still able to secure the position by demonstrating relevant experience and strong capabilities. **I became the first non-French-speaking member** of the Dior team, which was unexpected for many people. Although I can understand some French, **I had to rely on my experience to compensate for this gap.**

Overall, **I think many students become discouraged when they see strict language requirements in job postings, but there can still be flexibility if you are able to demonstrate your value.** Even if you do not meet all the listed requirements, it is still worth applying and trying, because **experience and networking can sometimes outweigh formal qualifications.**

Q: What is the company culture like, and how does the work culture in France differ from Korea?

A: The company culture at Thélios is relatively relaxed and flexible, especially compared to traditional Korean corporate environments. Since Thélios is a younger company within LVMH, the atmosphere feels less hierarchical and more open, with younger managers and greater freedom in how you work. Compared to both Korean companies and even some LVMH headquarters teams, the environment feels more informal and less rigid.

One of the biggest differences is how time and productivity are managed. **In France, there is no strict attendance system.** You can typically arrive anytime between 9 and 10 a.m., leave once your work is done, and take breaks freely throughout the day. There is much less direct supervision, which means employees are expected to manage their own time and responsibilities. Performance is evaluated through monthly or annual reviews rather than by how long you stay in the office.

People often have the misconception that employees in France take unlimited breaks, but interestingly, this flexibility actually leads to a faster-paced and more focused work environment. Because people want to finish their work efficiently and leave earlier, they tend to stay very focused during working hours. This is quite different from Korea, where there is often an expectation of staying late, which can sometimes lead to lower efficiency during the day. In contrast, the office environment in Paris is more results-driven, and people tend to work quickly and independently to

complete their tasks. Overall, while the culture is **more relaxed on the surface, it requires a higher level of personal responsibility** and self-management.

Q: For your current role, what specific skills do you use most that you didn't expect to be so important?

A: The most important skill in my role is **project management**, but what surprised me was not the skill itself, but the **level of responsibility** that comes with it. As the person managing projects end-to-end, I often act as the main point of coordination between different teams, which requires me to take ownership of both the overall direction and the detailed execution.

I did not expect to have such a high level of authority as the "middle person" in the process. In many cases, there is no one directly above me who has full visibility into the specific details of these projects, so I need to think independently and make decisions that balance both the bigger picture and the finer details. This means I have to manage multiple stakeholders while ensuring that everything aligns with the brand's standards, which requires a strong sense of responsibility, organization, and decision-making.

Q: From your experience, which roles offer the best learning opportunities early in a career, even if they're not the most obvious choices?

A: I believe that almost every role can offer valuable learning opportunities, because you often end up doing more than what is written in the job description. **It can be difficult to predict exactly what you will learn in a role, so instead of focusing on specific job titles, I think it is more useful to focus on the skills you want to develop.**

In my case, I was particularly interested in developing **project management skills, especially in understanding complex processes and coordinating different tasks.** Even though my role did not explicitly emphasize project management at the beginning, I was able to build those skills through my work. I think roles that involve **cross-functional communication are especially valuable early in your career**, because they allow you to interact with different teams, gain broader exposure to the business, and understand how different functions connect.

Compared to more specialized roles like merchandising, project

management roles can provide a wider perspective, especially at a more senior level where you are involved in global issues. This kind of exposure also helps you better understand your own interests and strengths.

Looking back, one mistake I made early in my career was starting in a very narrow field, which limited my options. I would recommend choosing roles that allow you to develop transferable skills and explore different areas, rather than focusing too early on a specific specialization.

Q: What is career progression like in LVMH?

A: This may be specific to France, but career progression in LVMH, can be quite different from what people expect. There is a strong reliance on interns and apprentices, as most students are required to complete internships or work-study programs during their Master's. As a result, **many entry-level roles are filled through these pathways rather than direct full-time hiring.** In many cases, companies hire interns to support teams instead of immediately offering full-time contracts, and once an internship ends, they simply bring in a new intern rather than convert the previous one.

Because of this structure, full-time conversion can be very low, around 20% in some maisons, although it varies by brand. For example, Dior rarely offers full-time contracts after internships, while companies like Thélès, which are still growing, may have higher conversion rates. It is also common for people to remain in internship or assistant-level roles for an extended period, sometimes working in positions that resemble full-time roles but without the same level of compensation or job security.

Once you secure a permanent contract, however, career progression becomes much more stable. In France, indefinite contracts (with no specific end date) offer strong job security, which is why companies are often cautious about offering them. After obtaining one, it becomes easier to move up the career ladder.

Salary progression, however, does not always keep pace with promotions. It is **common for professionals to change companies every few years to achieve higher salaries or better positions.** Compared to Korea, where salary increases may be higher but promotion to senior roles is more limited, France offers more structured career progression but slower salary growth. For international employees, this can mean staying in more junior roles while gradually increasing compensation, often by moving between companies.

Q: For students who don't necessarily have a background in luxury or fashion, what can they do to break into roles like yours? Have you seen people successfully transition into this industry from unrelated backgrounds?

A: From my experience, it is quite difficult to enter the luxury industry without some form of relevant background. Most of my colleagues started their careers in fashion, luxury, or related fields such as cosmetics or perfume brands. I have not personally seen many people successfully transition directly from completely unrelated industries, especially at the early-career level. Even for roles like marketing, e-commerce, operations, or project management, most candidates tend to have either an educational background in fashion or luxury management, or a general business degree such as an MBA.

That said, it is still possible to build a pathway into the industry by developing relevant exposure. **It does not have to be directly in luxury, but having some connection to the industry is important. This can include internships, part-time roles in retail, or any experience related to brands you are interested in.** Demonstrating genuine interest and passion is especially important, as the luxury market is currently quite competitive and companies are becoming more selective in their hiring.

I would recommend taking any opportunity to **build that connection, whether through research, hands-on experience, or additional education.** For example, there are programs like the **"Inside LVMH" course**, which is a free 30-hour program that introduces the luxury industry. Completing these types of programs can help show your interest and commitment. Overall, the key is to actively create touchpoints with the industry and build a profile that reflects both your interest and relevant experience.

Inside LVMH: <https://www.insidelvmh.com/certificate>



Ilaria Brizio

Former Sales Associate at Louis Vuitton Monaco

Q: Why specifically did you choose to work at Louis Vuitton instead of other brands?

A: For me, it was the heritage and superior quality. Louis Vuitton is not just a brand, it's a maison with a long-lasting identity and history. Compared to other companies, that stability, combined with global prestige, was very compelling and made me feel as if it would be an excellent path for career growth.

Q: How does working in a global company change the way your team works?

A: Everything is very **structured**. Whether you are in Monaco, Paris, or Tokyo, the client experience still feels consistent. Also, the team in our store was made up of people from very **different backgrounds**, all fluent in different target languages. Sometimes that requires a lot of adjusting to different cultural norms, and learning to work seamlessly together in a global team is different compared to a team that would be 100% Italian, 100% french, etc.

Q: What is the career progression like?

A: There are structured paths: from Client Advisor to Senior Client Advisor, then potentially Team Manager, Store Manager, or roles within the corporate structure. **The maison offers internal growth, but progression is tied closely to performance, client portfolio development, and alignment with brand values and KPIs.**

Q: Looking back, what do you wish you had known about the job?

A: That **this role is as much about psychology as it is about fashion**. You really have to understand people and their preferences to be good at it. You have to create a very specific type of experience, and it's not always easy.



SEPHORA

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**CAREER DEVELOPMENT SKILLS AND STRATEGIES
GROUP A (SEPHORA/LVMH)**

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